

## The Ultimate 'The' Guide

The definite article 'the' is one of the trickiest aspects of English grammar – even advanced learners struggle with it! One of the most common mistakes is adding 'the' where it doesn't belong, like '**I always eat the breakfast**' or '**What are you doing for the Christmas?**' In this lesson, we'll explore 18 situations in which we NEVER use 'the', from names and locations to meals and languages. Master these patterns and your English will sound much more natural!

### 1 Names

We don't use **'the'** before people's names. So it's not:

- ~~The~~ Lucy is my teacher. ❌

It's just

- Lucy is my teacher. ✅

We also don't use **'the'** when we have a title and a person's name.

- Doctor Keynes is on her way. ✅
- Mr Lawson has just left. ✅



We use **the** before pluralised surnames. These often refer to a family group:

- We invited **the Hammonds**. Simon and Rachel are coming.

### Exceptions

Now, are there exceptions to this? Yes, there are always exceptions in English! Take this example:

- Andy just got a new dog.
  - Do you mean **the Andy** who lives down the road? ✅

When we're identifying a specific person or thing, we use **'the'**. This is true in many cases throughout this lesson. But in general, we don't use 'the' before names.

**Pronunciation note:** For emphasis, we sometimes use the strong form of 'the' /ði:/ before names, even if they start with a consonant sound:

- Katy Perry? You mean **THE** /ði:/ Katy Perry?!

This shows surprise or excitement about someone well-known.

## 2 Continents

We don't use **'the'** before the names of continents.

- Asia is a very large continent. ✓
- Botswana is in Africa. ✓

Not ~~'the'~~ Asia' or ~~'the'~~ Africa'. ✗

Keep in mind that we don't use **'the'** before certain regional descriptors, like northern and southwestern:

- She lives in northern Scotland. ✓

We also don't use **'the'** before more official regional names, like Southeast Asia and Eastern Europe.

- Thailand is in Southeast Asia. ✓

## 3 Most Countries

Did you notice that we didn't have 'the' before Botswana, either? We don't use **'the'** before the names of MOST countries.

- I'd like to visit Canada. ✓
- Brazil produces a lot of coffee. ✓

Not ~~'the'~~ Canada' or ~~'the'~~ Brazil'. ✗

We don't use **'the'** before the names of US states or UK counties.

- He's from Texas. ✓
- She lives in Yorkshire. ✓

### Exceptions

Some country names usually take '**the**', like the United Kingdom, the United States and groups of islands, like the Philippines.

Generally, we tend to use 'the' before countries that contain the words 'Kingdom' or 'Republic' or are in the plural form:

- **the** United Kingdom
- **the** Dominican Republic
- **the** Netherlands/**the** Maldives/**the** Philippines

However, we don't always have to. For example, in the Oxford Learner's Dictionary, you'll see **(the) Philippines** and **(the) Dominican Republic**, indicating that 'the' is optional. It's best to use the same form as people from that country do or the form most people around you use.

We don't use 'the' before Ukraine, though in the past, this was common among English speakers.

## 4 Towns and Cities

We don't use '**the**' before the names of towns and cities.

- He lives in London. ✓
- Tokyo is my favourite city. ✓

Not ~~the~~ London' or ~~the~~ Tokyo'. ✗

The Hague in the Netherlands has 'the' within its name. But it's not:

- We work in ~~the~~ The Hague. ✗
- We work in The Hague. ✓

## 5 Street Names, Squares and Parks

Street names, squares and parks usually don't require the use of **'the'**.

- I live on Cherry Tree Avenue. ✓
- Times Square is one of the most famous places in New York City. ✓
- Let's rent a bike and ride through Hyde Park. ✓

## 6 Lakes and Mountains

Now, let's talk about natural geographical features. We don't say:

- ~~The~~ Lake Como is in Italy. ✗

We don't use 'the' before the names of most lakes and mountains.

- Lake Como is in Italy. ✓
- Climbing Mount Everest is very dangerous. ✓

Some do take the, such as **the** Eiger  
and sometimes **the** Matterhorn.

Mountain ranges take 'the':  
**the** Himalayas, **the** Andes.

## 7 Public Buildings and Institutions

Don't use **'the'**, especially if the first word is the name of a place or a person.

- I'll meet you at Manchester Airport. ✓
- St Pancras is a beautiful train station. ✓
- She's at Yale University. ✓

Other buildings often take 'the': **the** Eiffel Tower, **the** Taj Mahal, **the** White House.

In the case of universities, we use 'the' when university names are written as "**The University of X**", eg. **The** University of Cambridge. We also say **The** Open University. 'Open' is not the name of a place or person.

## 8 Shops and Restaurants

We also don't use '**the**' before shops and restaurants named after people. These names tend to end in **-s** or **apostrophe-s**.

- Do you want to grab a burger at Wendy's? ✓
- Harrods is an expensive shop in London. ✓

## 9 Company Names and Airlines

In fact, most company names, including airlines, don't take '**the**'.

- Apple makes phones and other electronic devices. ✓
- I flew to London on British Airways. ✓

Not '~~the~~ Apple' or '~~the~~ British Airways'. ✗

## 10 School, Prison, University and Church

We don't tend to use '**the**' with the words **school**, **prison**, **university** and **church** when we're referring to those places as a general idea, particularly when we're talking about a student, a prisoner or a person who regularly attends church.

- I went to school in a small town. ✓
- He's in prison. ✓

### Exceptions

We often use **'the'** before those words when we're visiting.

- We went to **the** prison to see Tate. ✓  
(They're visiting prison; they're not prisoners.)
- She's going to **the** church to find Reverend Marks. ✓  
(She is visiting the church on a specific occasion.)

## 11 Hospital

Let's talk about 'hospital'. In the same way as with 'school' and 'prison', we don't use **'the'** when talking about the general idea of a hospital and someone as a patient.

- Ruth's in hospital. ✓

So, that means 'Ruth's in ~~the~~ hospital' is wrong?

No, it's not, especially in North American English. In British English, we don't tend to use 'the' before 'hospital' when referring to the place in general. But in North American English, people usually do. Use whichever you prefer.

## 12 Expressions with Work, Home and Bed

One more place-related group: We don't tend to use **'the'** in expressions with the words **'work'**, **'home'** and **'bed'**. These are often with verbs like **'go'**, **'stay'**, **'start'** and **'finish'**.

- Joe starts work at 7. ✓
- She's staying at home tonight. ✓
- I'm going to bed. ✓

## 13 Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner and Supper

Now, let's talk about meals. We don't use **'the'** before **'breakfast'**, **'lunch'**, **'dinner'** or **'supper'**. In the introduction, you saw this sentence:

- I always eat ~~the~~ breakfast.

We know it's incorrect, so let's remove 'the' and look at some correct examples:

- I always eat breakfast. ✓
- What do you fancy for lunch? ✓
- I usually have fruit for supper. ✓

We can use 'the' when referring to a specific meal:

- **The** breakfast that the hotel offered was incredible. ✓

## 14 Festivals and Celebrations

You also saw this sentence in the intro:

- What are you doing for ~~the~~ Christmas? ✗

We now know it's not right either. We don't use **'the'** before many festivals and celebrations, including **'Christmas'**, **'New Year's Eve'** or **'Day'**, **'Easter'**, **'Hanukkah'** and **'Diwali'**.

- What are you doing for Easter? ✓
- Diwali usually falls in October or November. ✓

You'll hear people refer to 'the new year' more generally with the meaning of 'the coming year'.

- I'll see you in **the** new year.

## 15 Months

Using **'the'** before months is another no-no, generally.

- June is my favourite month. ✓
- We usually celebrate Easter in March or April. ✓

It's not ~~'the~~ June', ~~'the~~ March or April'. ✗

We can use **'the'** when identifying specific months:

- They were both born in '87. Ann was born in **the** September and Thomas in **the** October. ✓
- This is **the** August issue of the magazine. ✓

## 16 Times of Day

We don't use **'the'** before some times of day. Which is correct?

- We went in the morning.
- We went at the night.

Yep, the first one is fine, just like we could say 'in the afternoon' or 'in the evening' but the second isn't. We don't usually use 'the' if we can use the preposition **'at'** before the word. This includes **'night'**, **'dawn'** and **'dusk'**.

- We went for a walk along the beach at dawn. ✓
- We waited until dusk before lighting the campfire. ✓

**Twilight** is an exception to the rule above. We can say **'at twilight'**:

- The light here is beautiful at twilight. ✓

But we can also say in the twilight:

- Everything looks different in **the** twilight. ✓

## 17 Languages

We also don't tend to use **'the'** before languages.

- English is hard. ✓
- I'm studying Japanese. ✓

In this context, it would be wrong to say **'the English'** or **'the Japanese'** when referring to languages. ✗



We use **'the'** when referring to a specific variety of a language or when the word 'language' is included.

- **The** English spoken in South Africa differs from the English spoken in the UK. ✓
- **The** German language is difficult to learn. ✓

## 18 General Plural and Uncountable Nouns

Let's finish off with some more general categories. We don't usually use **'the'** before general plural or uncountable nouns.

- They love animals. ✓
- I play tennis on Tuesdays. ✓ (Not **'the'** tennis. ✗)

I often hear my students use 'the' before sports, games and other forms of exercise, but we don't tend to:

- We like football. ✓
- He does yoga. ✓
- She plays chess. ✓

Another example with uncountable nouns:

- Do you take sugar in coffee or tea?  
(Not **'the'** sugar, **'the'** coffee or **'the'** tea. ✗)

But you might have heard 'the animals' or 'the tennis' and it PROBABLY wasn't wrong. For example:

- **The** tennis I play with my friends is very different from the tennis played at Wimbledon! ✓  
(Those specific ways of playing.)
- **The** coffee I had at Jane's was delicious. ✓  
(That specific coffee, not coffee in general.)
- I love **the** animals that come into our garden at night. ✓  
(Those animals in particular, not all animals.)

Similarly, when speaking generally, we don't use **'the'** before uncountable abstract nouns, such as **'love', 'hate', 'hope'** and **'peace'**.

- Love makes people do strange things. ✓
- Peace is important for a happy life. ✓

Use **'the'** to be specific.

- **The** love they shared lasted a lifetime.

## Quiz Questions & Answers

**Do we need to add 'the' anywhere in this sentence?**

1. American Airlines is based in Fort Worth.

**Is this sentence correct?**

2. Tomorrow, I'm helping at the school where my son works.

**Is this sentence correct?**

3. Cocoa beans are grown in the Africa.

**Are you more likely to hear this in British or North American English?**

4. Marco is in the hospital.

**Do we need to add the?**

5. Manila is the capital of Philippines.

1. No 2. Yes 3. No. (No 'the' before continents.) 4. North American English 5. No 'the' before Manila - option before Philippines.



## Quiz

For each question, choose the correct answer from the options provided.

### 1. Which sentence is correct?

- a) The James lives in Bristol.
- b) James lives in the Bristol.
- c) James lives in Bristol.

### 2. Which country name is missing 'the'?

- a) She's travelling to United Kingdom.
- b) He visited Japan last year.
- c) I've never been to Belgium.

### 3. Which sentence correctly uses an article with an institution?

- a) He went to the prison to deliver a lecture.
- b) She's still at the university, studying politics.
- c) He's going to the school - he's a pupil there.

### 4. Which sentence uses 'the' correctly with a general noun?

- a) She enjoys yoga and plays football.
- b) She enjoys the yoga and plays football.
- c) She enjoys yoga and plays the football.

### 5. It's correct to say "Mount Fuji is in Japan" without using 'the'.

- a) True
- b) False

### 6. You must always use 'the' before the word 'hospital', even in British English.

- a) True
- b) False

### 7. Which sentence is correct?

- a) We travelled through the Asia.
- b) They climbed Mount Everest.
- c) She visited the Lake Como.

### 8. Which sentence is grammatically correct regarding celebrations?

- a) What are you doing for the Christmas?
- b) Diwali is usually celebrated in October.
- c) We love the New Year's Eve.

## Answers:

1. c 2. b 3. b 4. a 5. a 6. b 7. b 8. b

